

January

7

1990

Dangerous angle

Tilting more than 5 m (16 ft), the Leaning Tower of Pisa in Italy was closed for the first time in its 800-year history for urgent restoration work to stop it from toppling over.



1958

The Flying V

US guitar makers Gibson patented the futuristic Flying V electric guitar. Sales were slow at first, but rock stars like Jimi Hendrix turned this V-shaped instrument into a music icon.



1785

Up, up, and away!

French inventor John-Pierre Blanchard and US scientist John Jeffries became the first people to fly between countries, when they travelled from the UK to France in a hot-air balloon.

Also on this day

1914 French boat *Alexandre La Valley* was the first to sail along the Panama Canal, which connects the Atlantic and Pacific oceans.

1939 In a lab in Paris, French physicist **Marguerite Perey** discovered Francium, an extremely rare radioactive element.

1985 Japan launched *Sakigake*, its first interplanetary spacecraft.

Born this day

1985 **Lewis Hamilton**, British Formula 1 driver. He has broken the record for Formula 1 wins, but he is also an avid campaigner against racism, championing diversity in motor sports.